

Predicting Electoral Success

Campaign Characteristics and Structural Advantages in U.S. Elections

I. Data Overview

We chose to use the Primary Election Endorsements and Financing Dataset provided, specifically FiveThirtyEight: 2022 Primary Candidate Endorsements, which was data generated from state election officials, social media, and organization websites, and Federal Election Commission (FEC): Campaign Financing Data for Candidates (2021-2022), which contained data for every candidate either registered with the FEC or on an official state ballot for a House race. To include additional features, we added FiveThirtyEight: House Election Results which contains election results from November 1998 to present, USDA: Unemployment and Median Household Income which was generated from the BLS and U.S. Census Bureau's SAIPE program, and JoshData's Github: Historical State Population which is data generated from population estimates by the U.S. Census. All of these datasets were downloaded as CSV files. After merging, we had a near census of the 2022 House race with 3,606 candidates and 403 distinct elections represented. Each row represents a 2022 US House candidate, along with their election characteristics, campaign finance totals, endorsements, state attributes, and general election outcome. Because of this, our findings are at the candidate level and may not be as generalizable to elections outside of the 2022 House races.

Potential concerns with our data are that due to the nature of the FEC data generation, candidates that didn't register with the FEC or appear on an official state ballot were systematically excluded, which, by proxy, means write-in and third-party candidates. Additionally, candidates who could not be matched by state, district, and last name when merging were excluded. Because of this, there is potential selection bias as certain groups of candidates were excluded. There is also a minor concern with convenience sampling due to the exclusion of candidates who could not be matched. Moreover, potential measurement errors include state-level attributes being a noisy proxy for district-level elections. The two main features we wish we had are the competitiveness of a race and candidate quality. Knowing how competitive a race was would help separate the effect of funding from the fact that some races are heavily partisan where the winner is obvious, and that more competitive races likely draw more funding. When it comes to candidate quality, this would help with separating whether high fundraising leads to wins or that high quality candidates just raise more and are more likely to win. There are also columns with missing data that stem from the endorsement dataset missing some of the candidates in the FEC data, likely because those candidates didn't receive any of the

tracked endorsements. To deal with this, we marked candidates not in the endorsement dataset as not receiving any endorsements and marked their missing attributes as unknown.

The first step in our preprocessing was to filter for candidates in the 2022 House elections and merge our datasets based on state, district, and the candidate's last name. This was because we only had endorsement data for 2022, and all the datasets had those three features in common. When it came to districts, in some of the datasets, districts would be labeled as “at-large” or “00,” thus, we standardized it to “1,” how our election results data was formatted. We also created a feature to identify the House race and a feature to track the number of candidates in each race to control for confoundedness. We then included state-level features – median income, unemployment rate, and population – in our data for the same reason. Additionally, we grouped all non-major party affiliations into a third-party label for simplicity. These decisions made our dataset more usable and consistent for modeling, but also meant our inferences would be harder to generalize to other election types and cycles.

II. Research Questions

Our first research question is how does total funding received for a House candidate influence their likelihood of winning the election. By answering this, donors, parties, and campaigns can have a better idea of how much money to invest in a candidate and the impact this may have on the candidate's success. Causal inference is the best approach since we care about the effect of funding on a candidate's probability of winning, not just whether high-fundraising candidates tend to win. We need to isolate the causal effect by framing funding as the treatment, winning as the outcome, and then using causal inference to control for confounding variables and get an estimate. The main limitation is the unconfoundedness assumption. In this context, we assume that, conditional on the confounding variables we have, funding is as good as randomly assigned. However, this may not be completely true as there are important features unavailable, such as candidate quality and race competitiveness, which can influence both fundraising and winning, biasing our estimates.

Our second research question is, given candidate and campaign data (incumbency, party affiliation, etc.), are candidates positioned to win their election? Through addressing this, parties and campaigns can model and predict which races are most at risk and require funding and resources. Prediction with GLMs is a great approach as predictive features are transformed into binary variables. It can then be compared to a nonparametric method, in this case a random forest, to see if prediction accuracy improves and see which predictor relationships are most impactful. The main limitation of our models is how there are unobserved features that are important predictors but cannot be accounted for. As a way to reduce overfitting, we use techniques such as limiting tree depth and setting a maximum number of observations per tree.

III. Prior Work

In the paper “Money in Politics: How Does It Affect Election Outcomes?” by Thanh Le et al., they analyzed all U.S. House general elections from 2000 to 2018. They modeled the probability that a candidate wins as a function of log campaign expenditure and log contributions, while controlling for incumbency, party, age, gender, and state fixed effects (Le et al., 2024). The question they address is relevant as it combines our two research questions, predicting win probability given campaign spending and funding. It raises the question of whether the impact of campaign finances is causal, our first question, and provides a baseline comparison for our second question, since we factor in more predictors than campaign finances. In their approach, they estimate logit and linear probability models and then use Lewbel’s heteroskedasticity-based IV method to address endogeneity of contributions and spending. They found that both spending and funding increase a candidate’s probability of winning, but that effects were stronger for challengers relative to incumbents. Their approach is similar to ours in treating winning as the outcome and campaign finances as key predictors while controlling for incumbency and party, but differs in that they use panel data over many election cycles and a more advanced IV strategy. Because we do not implement IV or panel methods and focus on a single election cycle, our estimates will likely be more sensitive to 2022-specific patterns and remaining endogeneity in funding; thus, we will interpret our causal claims more cautiously.

In another paper, “The Effects of Campaign Spending in House Elections” by Gary Jacobson, the 1986 House elections were analyzed using voter-level survey data from 38 districts alongside candidate spending data to model the probability that a respondent would vote for the challenger candidate (Jacobson, 1990). He used a logit function of party affiliation, views on the president and economy, and the candidates’ campaign spending. The question addressed is relevant because it shows how the marginal effect of money depends on voters’ party affiliations and political views, which helps guide our thinking on the causal effect of money on election outcomes and the predictive capabilities of money as a feature. This study found that money is most impactful by shifting vote probabilities at the margin. Their approach is different since they factored in features that we aren’t considering, such as views on the president/economy, and used voter-level data instead of candidate-level. Therefore, their approach can separate the influence of money on different kinds of voters. In contrast, our simpler candidate-level GLMs and nonparametric models will only capture average effects across voters, so we may overlook some

of the differences he observed, and our results may be less informative about the best contexts for additional spending.

IV. Exploratory Data Analysis

Research Question 1:

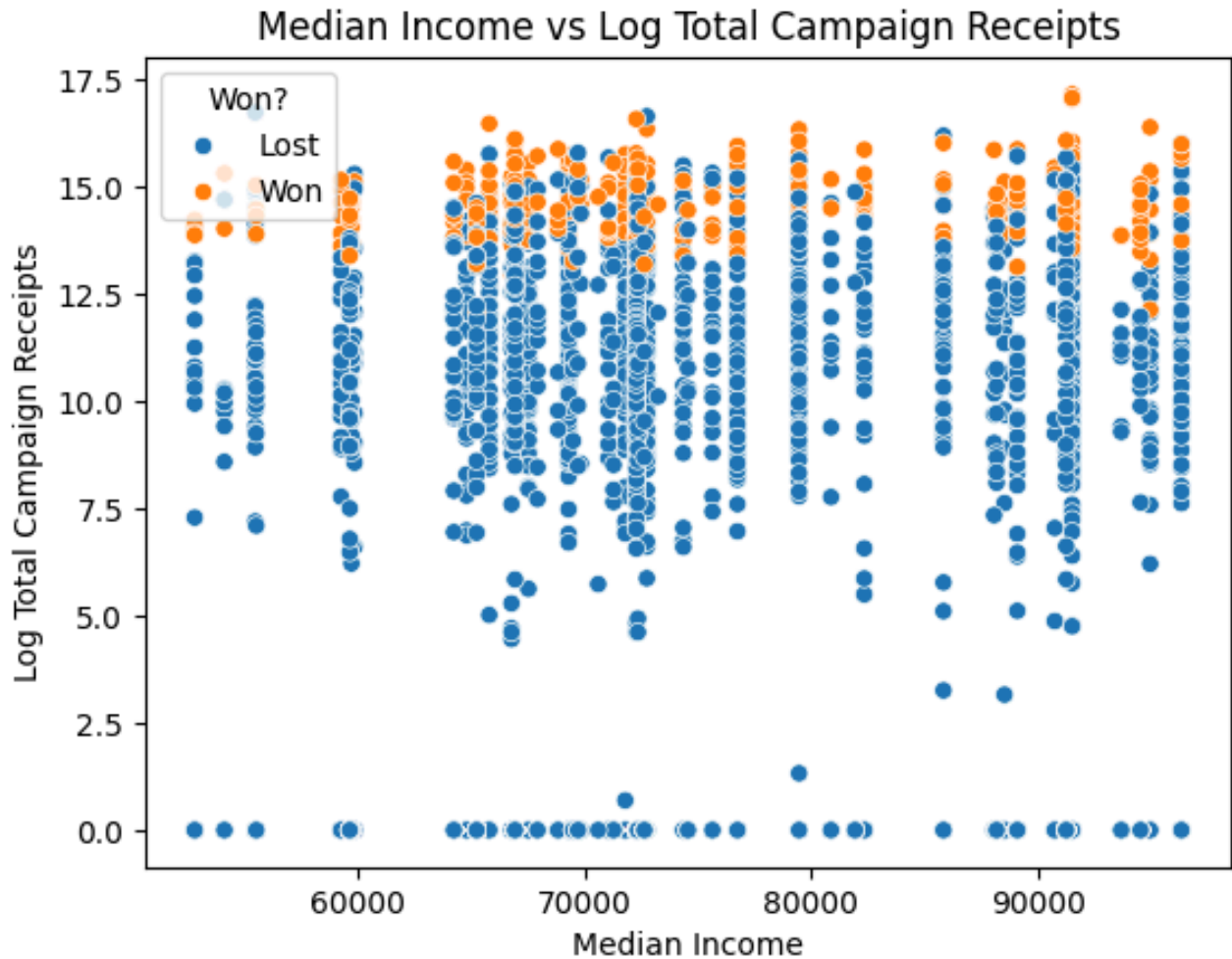


Figure 1: Log Campaign Receipts for Candidates vs Median Income for Their Respective State

This visualization compares median income for a candidate's respective state to their campaign's log-transformed total receipt. In other words, if a candidate was from a wealthier state as quantified by a greater median income, we wanted to see if they received greater funding as a result of wealthier constituents. However, from this visualization we can see that this is not necessarily the case and knowing just median income for a candidate's state doesn't help us gauge how much funding their campaign will receive.

There is not a clear linear trend between median income and campaign receipts, indicating that candidates from wealthier states with greater median incomes don't necessarily receive more campaign receipts. Aside from the candidates who received log campaign receipts

close to \$0, the candidates closest to a log receipt amount of ~ 2.5 -3 were from states that had higher median incomes between \$80,000 - \$90,000 and not less wealthy states. By overlaying candidate success in elections, candidates who receive the greatest amount of campaign receipts across every level of median income are the ones who see the greatest success.

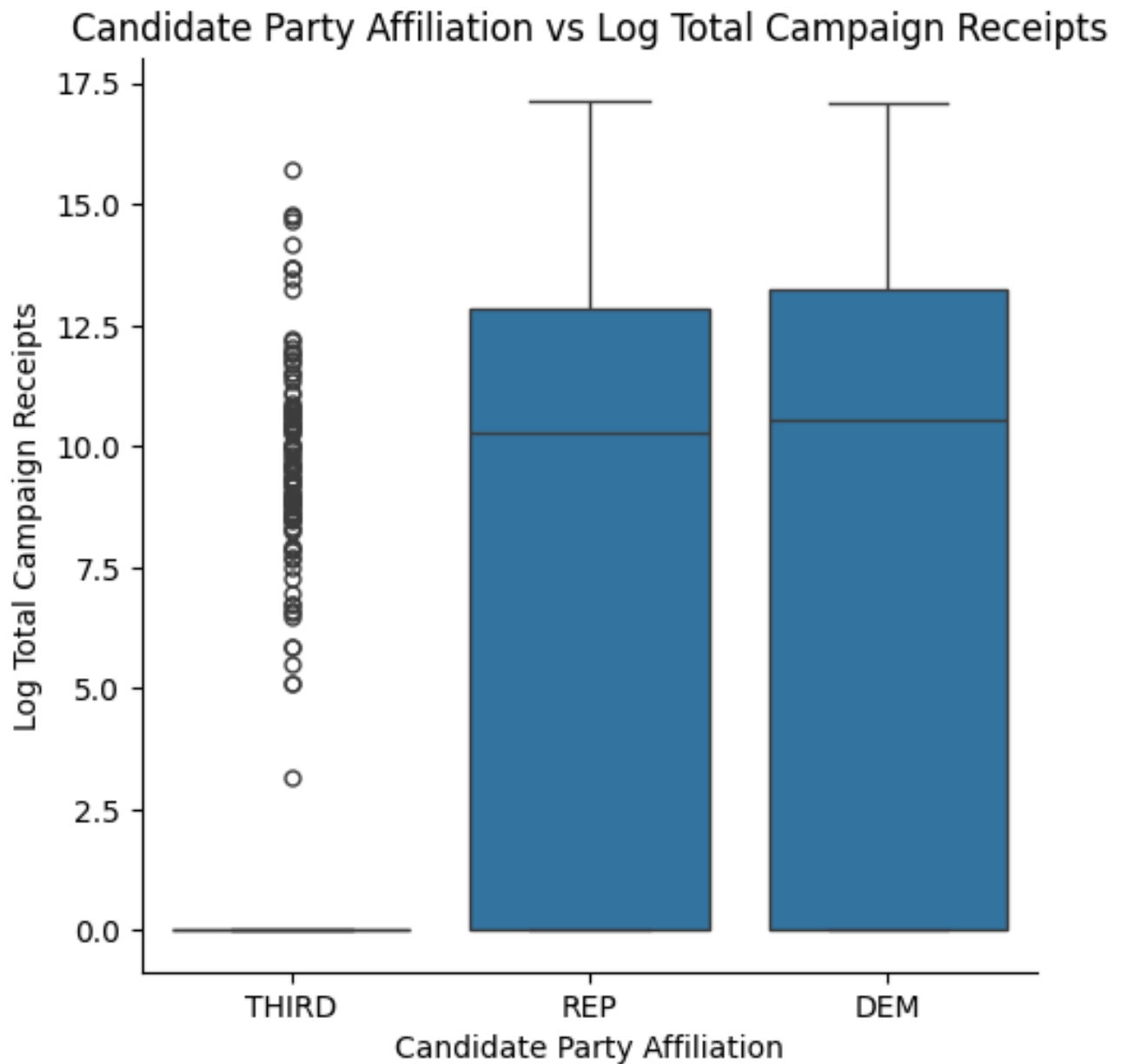


Figure 2: Log Total Campaign Receipts by Candidate Party Affiliation

This visualization analyzes how a candidate's party impacts the amount of funding they receive. Since we're analyzing the impact of funding on election success, we wanted to see if there was a political party gap in terms of campaign receipts during the 2022 election, and if that

translated to a party that received greater funding having more seats. This visualization provided us with the first part of this analysis.

We observe that third party candidates by far receive the least funding, with a plot centered entirely around 0 alongside a few outliers. Democrats and Republicans had comparable levels of log campaign receipts, with near-equal medians, maximum values, and lower bounds of 0. The only comparison that stood out to us was that Democrats had a slightly greater third quartile compared to Republicans.

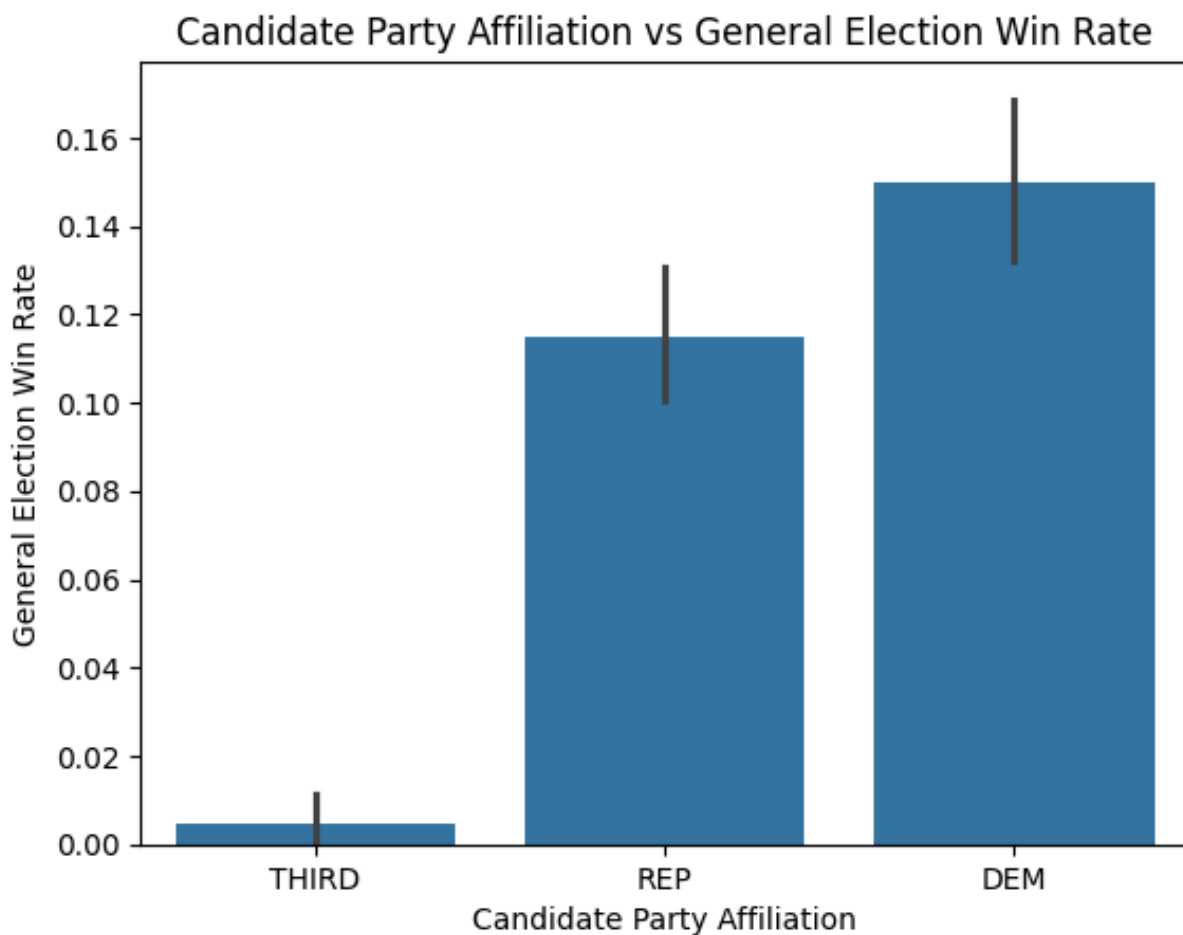


Figure 3: General Election Win Rate by Candidate Party Affiliation

This visualization provides us with a potential answer to the question posed before. We were able to compare election success between parties compared to their funding. Third party candidates received the least amount of funding, mostly 0, with a few outliers receiving more. We can see that this group also saw the lowest success in elections, with a significantly lower win rate than the other two parties. Democrats and Republicans had similar receipt distributions,

with Democrats having a slightly greater third quartile which suggests that it had a greater concentration of above-median receipts compared to Republicans. Democrats were also the party that saw the highest win rate of the three parties. So although there is not a clear association between funding of a political party and its general election success, we can see a pattern of the group with greatest receipts had better successes and the group with the lowest receipts saw the least success.

This visualization supports our prior beliefs that mostly Democrats and Republicans win elections and third-party candidates usually don't see great success. Less than 1% of candidates that won general elections identified as third-party. Democrats and Republicans saw relatively more reasonable levels of success with win rates of ~15% and ~11% respectively.

Research Question 2:

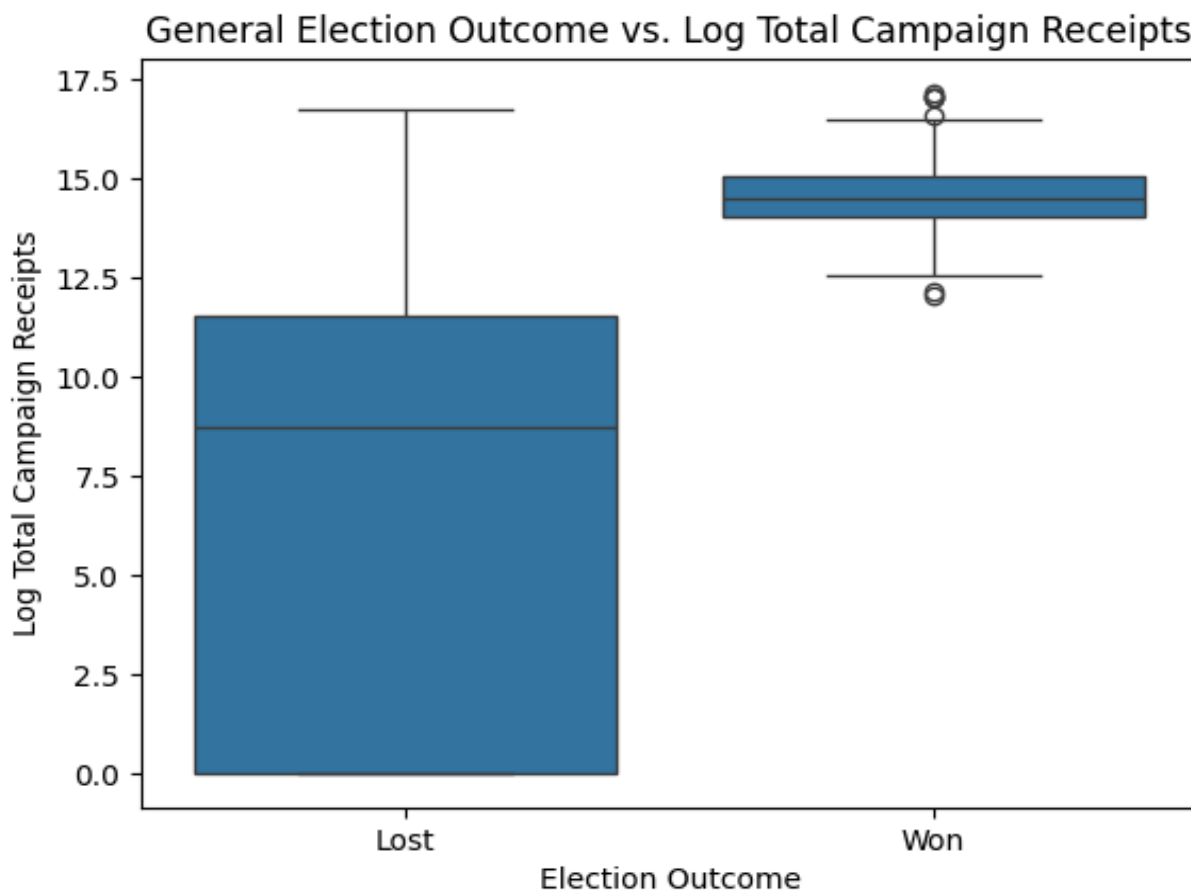


Figure 4: Log Total Campaign Receipts by Election Outcome

This visual shows that campaign receipts as a key predictor in our model is significant to helping answer our research question. While it's not determinative, it demonstrates that higher

total receipts is associated with winning and "positions" candidates to win much more likely. This analysis is relevant to our research question and represents how fundraising is an important key predictor.

After log-transforming the total receipts for interpretability, this boxplot shows how campaign fundraising is a big factor in general election outcome. Candidates who won the election have significantly higher log-transformed total campaign receipts and a higher median compared to candidates who lost. Candidates who lost also have more variability, indicating that there are many candidates with near-zero or very low receipts.

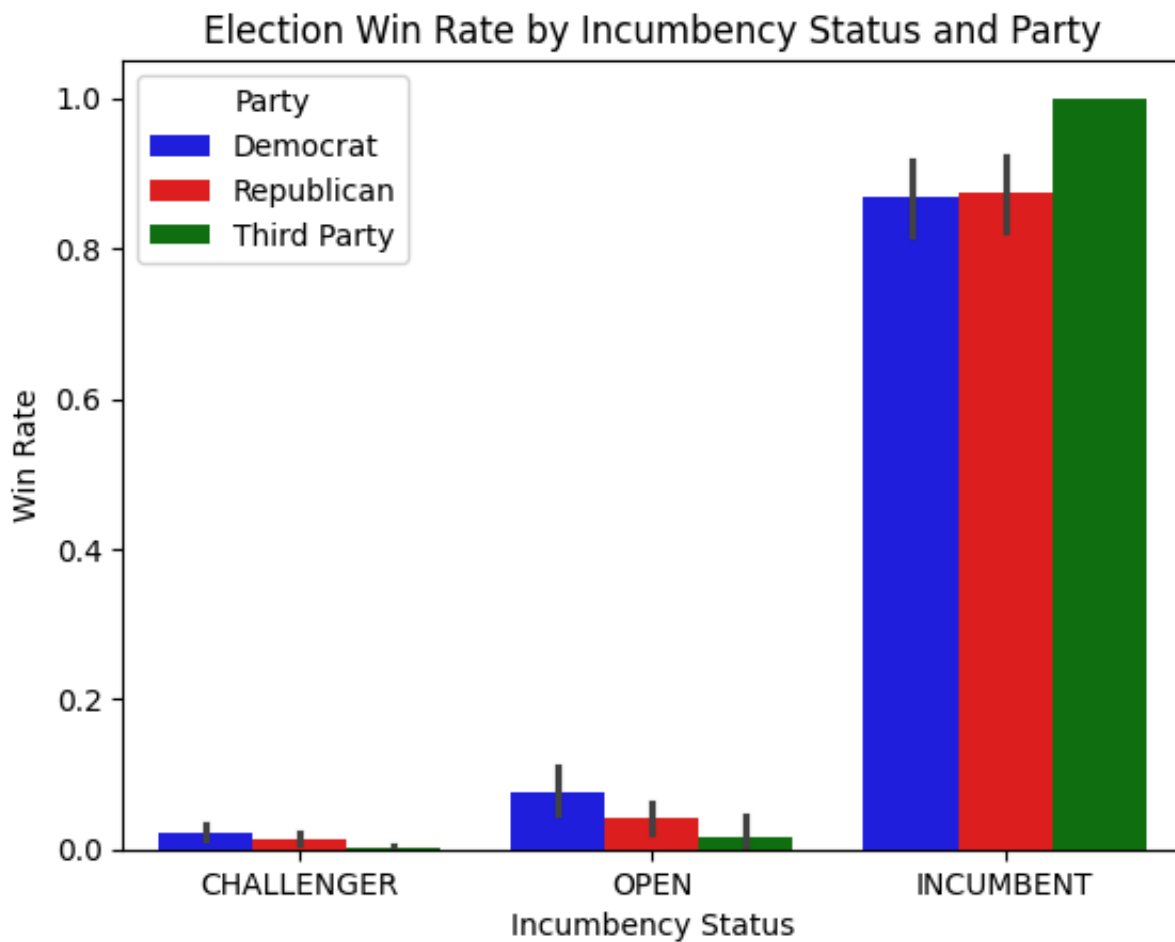


Figure 5: General Election Win Rate by Candidates' Incumbency Status and Political Affiliation

With our research question aiming to answer if candidates are positioned to win their election based on different factors, one being their incumbency status, this plot shows that this plays a large role in predicting if a candidate were to win their election or not. It also shows that this trend is consistent despite a candidate's political party. Therefore, this comparison of

categorical variables of incumbent status and political party highlights a key insight to our research question.

After grouping candidates by party and aggregating all non-Democratic and non-Republican parties into a single category under "Third Party", the visual above shows that there is a strong advantage for candidates who are incumbents. It can be seen that incumbents win most of their elections while non-incumbents have a much smaller chance to win theirs, regardless of political party. This shows that incumbent status is more significant to winning the general election when compared to political party differences.

V. Research Question 1: How does total funding received for a House candidate influence their likelihood of winning the general election?
(Causal Inference)

Methods:

The treatment corresponds to ‘log_Total_Receipt’ which is the logarithm of the amount of funding a campaign received over its course. The outcome is our ‘win_general_2022’ column, a binary indicator for whether or not a candidate won their respective general election.

We grouped confounders as those which would impact a candidate’s ability to raise money or influence their chances of winning their respective general election. We included candidate states (mapped as integers from 0-49), districts, and number of opponents for context on how competitive a race may be, and how large a role funding could play. Next, we evaluated the presence of endorsements from major political figures or political action committees which could impact their likelihood of winning with the presence of an endorsement raising greater funds. For demographic context, we included a candidate’s respective state’s unemployment rate, median income, and population to represent how many people could donate and provide economic context. Next, we evaluated a candidate’s incumbency status, since their past performance could impact their likelihood of re-election. We also accounted for candidates’ gender, race, and political affiliation since their demographic appeal could influence certain donor networks or voter preferences.

Under the unconfoundedness assumption, conditional on these aforementioned confounding variables, fundraising is assumed to be independent of general election outcomes. In reality, there are certainly additional variables at play such as campaign skill, candidate demographics, further district-level context, etc., but we attempted to include covariates that we thought would serve as reasonable proxies for these factors.

To adjust for confounders, we used generalized propensity scores since our treatment is continuous. We firstly estimated the conditional distribution of this treatment given the confounders that we identified and constructed stabilized inverse-density weights. We then applied these weights to a logistic regression model to attempt approximating a randomized experiment where fundraising is independent of the observed confounders.

Our original dataset does have some colliders related to campaign finances such as “Cash_On_Hand_COP”, “Total_Disbursements”, “Net_Contribution”. These metrics are influenced by the amount of money a campaign receives as well as its strategy or financial efficiency which could be influenced by the competitiveness of a race (fewer opponents allows for a less aggressive campaign).

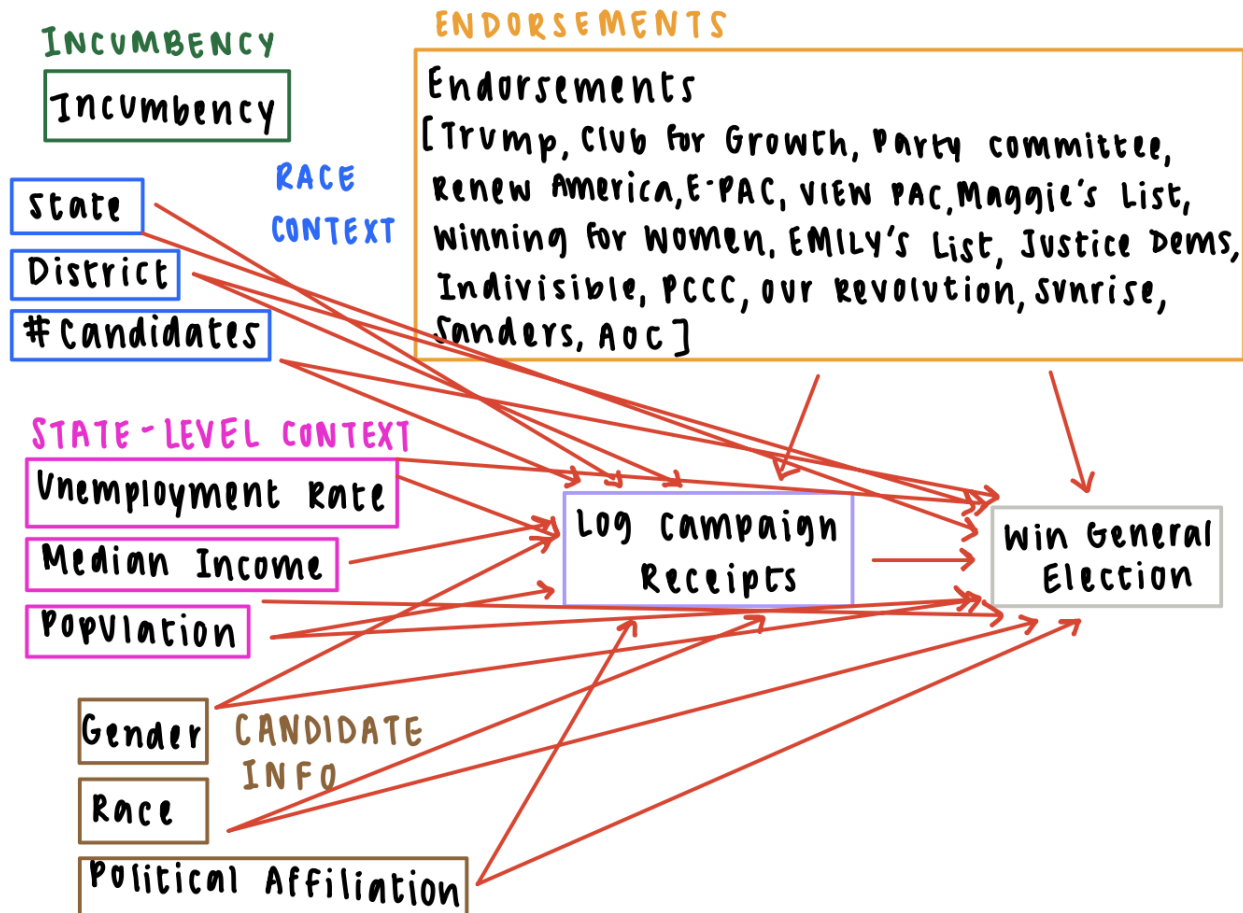


Figure 6: Causal Dag for our Treatment, Outcome, and Confounders

Results:

Our results show a positive relationship between high levels of campaign receipts and general election success. Specifically, the estimated coefficient, or beta, is 1.3544453590322765. This means that for a 1-unit increase in Log Campaign Receipts, we can see an $\exp(1.3544453590322765) = 3.87$ times greater chance in a candidate winning the general election. Similarly, a 10% increase in Log Campaign Receipts results increases the odds of a candidate winning by 1.1377952865254513 times, or ~14%.

Under the unconfoundedness assumption with our observed covariates, we can interpret this as a positive causal relationship where an increase in the amount a campaign receives results in a greater probability of the candidate winning their general election.

Additionally, we bootstrapped our results to find a 95% confidence interval for beta, our estimated coefficient, which gave us a range of (1.1617799, 1.59772718). Since 0 is not contained within this interval, we have sufficient evidence that a causal relationship between the log of campaign receipts and general election success exists. Similar to before, we can interpret these beta values as follows: for a 1-unit increase in Log Campaign Receipts, we can see a 3.2-4.94 times greater chance for the candidate winning the general election.

Discussion:

One limitation of our methods concerns the unconfoundedness assumption where we assumed that the confounders used for our models were the only ones jointly affecting campaign receipts and general election success. Although we did control for a large chunk of confounders, other factors such as reputation, media strength, donor networks, etc. aren't observed and could also impact fundraising and election outcomes. Second, inverse density weighting has the ability to inadvertently increase noise present in the data. Candidates whose observed fundraising levels are very unlikely given their covariates will receive greater weights, so a small number of abnormal observations can influence overall results. Finally, our model only measures the effect of campaign receipts on elections for all candidates. However, this effect may differ across various groups – for example, funding may play a larger role in campaigns for challengers than incumbents. From the analysis we did, we cannot yet determine in which scenarios or for whom greater campaign receipts matter the most, limiting the applicability of our results.

Additional data surrounding candidates themselves, district-level demographics, and political history could help further answer our research question – knowing their past experiences or years in office could also help us get a read on their qualifications and likelihood for winning elections. We used state-level demographics for candidates, but having district-level information would provide more granular information to understand constituents and their likelihood of funding campaigns. Finally, knowing a district's political history – for example, if it has voted Democrat for the past few decades – could be helpful in knowing a candidate's odds for being able to raise money and realistically get elected.

We are fairly confident that there is a positive causal relationship between the log of campaign receipts and winning general elections. After adjusting for observed confounders with generalized propensity score weighting, the estimated effect (beta) is positive and our bootstrapped 95% confidence interval also does not contain 0, indicating statistically significant results. However, there is a chance that these results are due to chance; in that case, a reasonable explanation for our observed results could be that donors choose to fund candidates that they believe have a high likelihood of winning the general election. They could reach this conclusion through having insider information, pre-election polling results, etc. where funding would be more indicative of a candidate's winning probability rather than a mechanism leading to their success.

Our results are similar to the findings from Le et al. (2024) and Jacobson (1990) in that more campaign funding is associated with a higher probability of winning, and that the influence of money mainly shifts outcomes at the margin rather than guaranteeing a victory. However, Le et al. use panel data over multiple years and an IV strategy, and Jacobson uses voter-level survey data, while we used a single election of candidate-level data with generalized propensity score weighting. Because our methods were simpler and we rely heavily on the unconfoundedness assumption, our results are more suggestive and prone to remaining endogeneity than the estimates in those prior works.

VI. Research Question 2: Given candidate and campaign data (incumbency, party affiliation, etc.), are candidates positioned to win their general election? (Prediction with GLMs and Nonparametric Methods)

Methods:

By using both a GLM and non-parametric model, our goal is to predict whether a candidate wins the general election using pre-election characteristics. Our predictive features for these models include: total campaign fundraising, log-transformed for easier interpretability ($\log_total_receipt$); endorsements, transformed into a binary variable to indicate if a candidate received at least one endorsement from an organization or politician; incumbency status, transformed into a binary variable to show whether a candidate is an incumbent, challenger, or running in an open seat; political party affiliation, organized by Democrat, Republican, and Third Party (all non-Democratic and non-Republican parties); race competitiveness, to show the number of candidates running and overall structure of the race. Additional features include state unemployment rate, state median income, and state population to measure local economic factors.

The GLM we're using is a frequentist logistic regression model. We chose to use this specific GLM because it's easily interpretable for binary outcomes, giving us clear analysis on how each predictive feature is correlated with the likelihood of winning. With our goal being simply to predict whether a candidate is likely to win, it's more efficient to use a simpler frequentist logistic regression model rather than a Bayesian logistic regression. While a Bayesian GLM can indicate uncertainty for each estimated effect, it would require well-justified priors, and in this case, there is limited, accurate prior information on the true magnitude of how each predictor affects the outcome. Taking all this into account, a frequentist GLM is the best choice for our goal in predicting which candidates are most likely to win. An assumption for this model is that there is a linear relationship between the predictors and log odds of winning, meaning that each predictor is assumed to have a consistent marginal effect when all other variables are held constant. Another assumption is that each candidate's outcomes are independent of other candidate outcomes. These assumptions allow us to evaluate how these predictors are associated with the likelihood of winning.

The nonparametric method we're using is a random forest classifier. Random forests are effective here because they can adapt to complex patterns in the data, identifying nonlinear relationships and interaction effects. For example, if the effect of total receipts differ depending on incumbency status, a random forest can account for the predictor's influence on the other. In addition, random forests make minimal assumptions and are robust to outliers, providing true relationships between predictors. By limiting tree depth and setting a minimum threshold for observations per leaf, this method ensures that predictive outcomes are derived from patterns to reduce the risk of overfitting. To accurately measure the impact of all these features, we transformed each one to a binary value and avoided interaction terms. An assumption for the random forest model is that there are enough observations in the dataset for the classifier to learn and accurately identify relationships. Another assumption is that the relationships it establishes stay mostly the same and aren't overly sensitive to small changes in the training data. Taking all this into account, random forests are a preferable choice for our analysis.

We evaluate both models using AUC as the primary performance metric. AUC measures a model's ability to rank winning candidates above losing candidates based on the learned relationships from the predictors without relying on a fixed cutoff. By comparing AUC for the two models, it demonstrates how effective each model is when it comes to identifying which candidates are positioned to win, directly answering our research question. While AIC is usually used to compare GLMs, it's less appropriate here because we want to prioritize predictive performance of unseen data, not just the training data. This evaluation strategy directly aligns with our goal of predicting election outcomes based on our predictive features.

Results:

When comparing the GLM to the random forest classifier, the GLM achieves an AUC of 0.58, indicating predictive ability only slightly better than random guessing. On the other hand, the random forest achieves a much higher predictive accuracy with an AUC of 0.98, showing near perfect predictability. This substantial difference suggests that nonlinear relationships among campaign and candidate features play a significant role in predicting election outcomes which is something that the GLM does not find. Although the GLM has a lower predictive accuracy, its findings offer us insight to more interpretable and broader trends, showing that factors such as higher fundraising, having at least one endorsement, and being an incumbent are positively correlated with the likelihood to win. This difference in outcomes demonstrates how

these two models have their own advantages and disadvantages. While the GLM gives directional insights on how each predictor correlates with election outcomes, the random forest prioritizes how complex, nonlinear relationships and interactions between predictors impact the predictive accuracy of the model.

When comparing a random winning candidate and a random losing candidate, the GLM model only correctly ranks the winner above the loser about 58% of the time. This percentage represents considerable uncertainty, showing that our logistic regression model was often uncertain about the outcome of specific races. Most of these races the model struggled with were open-seat or highly competitive races, implying that unobserved factors such as candidate charisma and local issues also play an essential role in predicting the winner. Overall, the GLM gives a directional baseline but not precise predictions for individual candidates.

Discussion:

The random forest significantly outperformed the logistic regression in predictive accuracy. To make sure our model results are accurate and not simply driven by a single predictor, we conducted a robustness check by removing the total fundraising variable from the feature set. After refitting the random forest without fundraising, the model still maintained a significantly high AUC of 0.93, implying that this outcome is not dependent on a single predictor. This reveals a broader trend in which additional factors also play a huge role in predicting election outcomes such as incumbency status and race competitiveness, providing greater confidence in our model's robustness.

While the random forest model displays superior performance, we have to still be cautious when applying this to future datasets. This is because the extremely high AUC implies that it could be exploiting structural patterns such as stronger incumbency advantages when predicting election outcomes. In contrast, the GLM model is likely to be more stable across datasets due to the model prioritizing more directional influences. With both models using the same predictors and test splits, the predictive performance of both results in a fair comparison.

Each model has its own limitations. The GLM model assumes linear effects on a candidate's probability to win in a simple and independent way, which oversimplifies the much more complex electoral process in practice. This limits its predictive accuracy but increases interpretability. On the other hand, the random forest, while highly accurate, does not have this

interpretability advantage and may exploit certain factors in its evaluation. This can result in an inflated accuracy score and be more of a risk when applying to future elections.

Having additional data would greatly improve the predictive accuracy and robustness of both models. One valuable addition would be incorporating historical electoral data, whether that be state-level voting history or historical partisan lean. Another possible addition could come from sourcing more candidate-level data such as campaign duration or prior elected positions, though these variables may be more difficult to collect and accurately measure. Lastly, there can be the addition of time-related features, whether that be the timing of fundraising or endorsements relative to the election.

Both the GLM and nonparametric models performed best in races where a candidate had clear campaign advantages such as being an incumbent or receiving a larger amount of funding than their competitors. The models performed worst in highly competitive elections where there is an open-seat. This is because there are more dynamic factors to consider in these cases, outside the predictive features we used. This exploration and inclusion of these features could further strengthen the model's predictive accuracy.

Our predictive results are quite similar with Le et al. (2024) and Jacobson (1990) in that GLM models only have modest prediction success when using fundraising and incumbency as they mainly capture general trends rather than perfect classification. Where our results differ is that we supplement our GLM with a random forest that achieves high AUC, around 0.98, something prior research does not report. This shows that while our GLM has similar results to their logistic regressions, our random forest has captured nonlinear patterns that improve predictive accuracy.

While the random forest achieves an exceptionally high predictive accuracy, this does not mean that elections are one-dimensional and simple to predict. Instead, these findings rather show the larger impact of strong institutional structures such as incumbency and endorsements that heavily influence the outcomes for an election. At the same time, the GLM's lower accuracy exhibits uncertainty in electoral processes, especially in competitive or open-seat races where unobserved influences are more impactful. All in all, these results imply that certain structural factors can make prediction slightly easier in some circumstances but uncertainty remains at a per race level.

VII. Conclusion

Outcomes Summary:

Through causal inference, we were able to find a positive relationship between the log of campaign receipts and winning general elections. This means that an increase in funds for a campaign was associated with a greater likelihood for election success. Our GLM and nonparametric comparison analysis finds that campaign and structural factors greatly influence a candidate's likelihood of winning a general election. In particular, total fundraising, incumbency status and endorsements.

Critical Evaluation:

We lack domain knowledge of fundraising for a candidate and how spending decisions are made. Knowing where funding for these candidates was coming from, such as individual donors, PACs, or party committees, would help us distinguish what fundraising is actually representing, voter enthusiasm or party-led investment. This would allow us to create a more informed question and select better features. One question we would ask a domain expert is: "What share of a candidate's funding comes from small individual donors vs. PACs and party committees, and how does that mix differ between safe and competitive races?" If we learned that PAC and party money mainly goes to safe candidates while small donors come out for competitive races, we might separate receipts into "grassroots" vs "institutional" money, and refine our causal question to focus on one type of funding instead of aggregating them into a single receipts variable.

Our results are based solely off 2022 House election data, so they aren't necessarily generalizable to other election years or races since many factors vary between elections (economic state, voter behavior, electoral situation, etc.). Our findings are also pertaining to a generic relationship between fundraising and general election outcomes for all candidates, there may be internal differences where funding plays a greater or lesser role depending on a certain factor. As mentioned above, our conclusions are based on a combination of interpretable and prediction focused modeling, validated through robustness checks, giving us confidence that our findings reflect meaningful patterns on election outcomes.

Recommendations:

A future study to build on our work would be to extend our analysis over a longer period of election cycles and include district-level features such as competitiveness and median income. Additionally, the study should use a stronger causal design such as an instrumental variable strategy to test whether our estimated causal effect of fundraising and predictive model results hold and are generalizable for elections for different offices and cycles.

Based on our results, we suggest that parties and donors should prioritize providing funding towards viable yet underfunded candidates in competitive races, especially challengers and open-seat candidates rather than incumbents with a high probability of getting re-elected. This recommendation is feasible for individual donors, parties, and PACs to implement, as polling data and seat statuses are publicly available. Everyone would have the right to object as strategic campaign funding can deepen the influence of wealth in politics and affect election outcomes. The main beneficiaries would be challenger candidates in competitive races, who would find it easier to raise money, and voters in those districts, who play a larger role in elections than other less competitive races. On the other hand, candidates deemed non-viable with a long shot of winning would find it harder to raise money as well as incumbents who may have underperformed during their term that now are facing better funded challengers. Our findings, if implemented, can help candidates understand how to best position their campaigns for success.

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